

Past Imperfect

Words and images that question many myths of the Revolt



DATELINE 1857: REVOLT AGAINST THE RAJ
by RUDRANGSHU MUKHERJEE,
PRAMOD KAPOOR
Roli Books; Pages: 144

■ By Gillian Wright

Rudrangshu Mukherjee has the distinction of having written both the smallest and the biggest book on 1857. The former was an account of the historical Mangal Pandey, written in response to the Hindi film of the same name. This book, *Dateline 1857*, has the feel and appearance of a vintage newspaper and is just as much a history of the Revolt in pictures as in prose. Its huge, sepia-tinted pages carry an abundance of illustrations from the period, assembled by Mukherjee's co-author, Pramod Kapoor. The photographs and prints are sometimes horrifying. Bodies hanging from makeshift gallows and rebel soldiers stretched across the mouths of British cannon. Imperious commanders and wild-eyed soldiers stare from the pages. An array of bentwood chairs stands in the last Mughal's deserted Diwan-e-Khas. The manacled figure of the man British officials thought to be Nana Sahib crouches terrified before the camera.

Mukherjee's analysis of the revolt is based on years of research. He sees it as a popular uprising born of the violence implicit in the British conquest of north India. The uprising destroyed all symbols of British power over most of north and central India—even when those symbols were women and children. This resulted in the savagery with which the British put down the Revolt. Mukherjee believes that an event which saw so much brutality on both sides demands not celebration, but examination and understanding. He explodes myths and gives original insights into many aspects of the Revolt. Never have the events of 1857 seemed so close or real. This is a book that richly deserves to be read. ■

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ON TENTERHOOKS:
Indian truck drivers held
hostage in Iraq in 2004

Near Miss in Mesopotamia

A taut rendering of the saga of the hostage crisis in Iraq, this book calls for the need of expert hostage negotiators



**ANATOMY OF AN ABDUCTION:
HOW THE INDIAN HOSTAGES
IN IRAQ WERE FREED**
by V. SUDARSHAN
Penguin Books
Price: Rs 295; Pages: 219

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

If the hostage drama of four Indian truck drivers kidnapped by Iraqi militants in 2004 does not figure at all in India's war on terror, it was because it was a bicycle accident compared to the train wreck that was the hijacking of IC814 to Kandahar in 1999.

Unlike the Afghan escapade where the foreign minister flew terrorists to swap with passengers, this four-month episode had a happy ending. This was partly because their kidnappers in the Iraqi resistance were not overtly hostile to India—thanks to our soft power and Bollywood—and were happy to extort the ransom from the Kuwaiti employers. The Kandahar episode was part of India's own war on terror. It underscored the importance of crisis management and expert hostage negotiators. These lessons well learned come in handy later and prevent this

saga from turning into an international mess-opotamia. So this drama that takes place five years after the hijacking becomes a book not so much about the hostages themselves but the team of negotiators flown down by the Indian government to the embassy in Baghdad to help Brij Bhushan Tyagi, the ambassador who lives in a room scattered with standard Iraqi accessory: the AK-47. There is Zikrur Rehman the babu in the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), Rakesh Sharma the team head and the Intelligence Bureau hand and MEA's veteran Arab hand, Talmiz Ahmed. Their drama is only a sideshow in the grand spectacle of a superpower embroiled in a quagmire and just one of thousands of cases of one of the fastest growing industries in a lawless land. The team has to navigate through the smoke and mirrors of Arab intrigue and unpredictability, while keeping India's involvement in the negotiations at a low profile.

Sudarshan brings to the four-month standoff, his journalistic fine eye for detail. He effortlessly transports the reader to the heart of a country torn by civil war and turns an otherwise dull account into an exciting page turner. ■